WOVEN TRUST

How a society governs itself by reputation, not by force.

The thesis

There is an old idea behind all of this, and it is simple: almost everything we do depends, one way or another, on the State. Permission, money, the judge, the registry, identity. To live is to ask permission. Harlequin is born of turning that around — not by tearing anything down, but by building, alongside, a place where you need ask no one's permission.

You do not fight power with its own weapon. Force is the State's ground; there it always wins. You fight it by taking away what it feeds on: dependence. Every person who learns to stand on their own takes a link off the chain. That is the whole ambition of the project, and also its patience: it is built slowly, in layers, with care. Something great is not raised in one blow.

The name and the face of the project is the Harlequin. In the old theatres he was the lowest on the stage: a servant in a patched suit, in the service of masters who believed they owned him. And yet, behind the mask, he was the freest of them all — he served with his body, but with his soul he served no one. There is the whole idea. Harlequin is born against no one, but in favour of something: of the freedom that is not begged for but kindled within, and of the name each person earns by their deeds. And with it comes its weight: whoever obeys no master also has no one to blame, and answers for all they do. To be one's own master is the prize, and also the burden.

What it is

Harlequin is a society that lives on the internet, on its own blockchain. It is not a company, not a coin to speculate with, not a social network. It is a voluntary order of cooperation: people who join, wear a mask, and take part in a community with its own rules, its own justice, and its own economy. No one knows who you are behind the mask — and yet you answer for what you do.

What changes everything: money does not give power

Almost everywhere, whoever has the most rules the most. Here, not so. Weight comes from reputation: what you contribute, how you behave, the trust you earn through your acts. Money is for trading and for saving, but it buys neither power nor voice. This is the first rule, and the most important. If some mechanism ever let money turn into authority, it would be violating the society's constitution.

This solves a deep problem. In any community an authority eventually rises — someone who decides for the others, and whom, sooner or later, you must obey. Harlequin sets no authority: it sets reputation. And it judges neither your ideas nor your beliefs — the society professes no official morality —; it measures only the trust you earn through your acts: whether you keep your word, whether you contribute, how you treat others. It is a transparent measure, one anyone can recompute for themselves, that cannot be bought or inherited. There is no official server that holds the truth. The truth is the chain, and the nodes hold it up.

The mask: anonymous, yet accountable

You join through an rite of entry and receive a mask. From then on you are anonymous: not your name, your face, or your trail leaks. But the mask carries your reputation — the good and the bad you do stays bound to it. So something hard is achieved: anonymity with accountability. And a hard rule protects it: justice judges what the mask did, and never tries to uncover who is behind it. Unmasking someone, even in the name of justice, is treated as an act of aggression.

Reputation is measured across four suits, as in a deck of cards, because each is a different way of being worth something:

You can be strong in one and weak in another. But to weigh on the whole — to have a voice in what affects everyone — you must be trustworthy in all four. You do not buy the authority of war with ambition. To be of weight means being sound across several hands, not a genius in one and a zero in the rest.

How the name is earned

Here nobody votes on anybody. No little stars, no likes, no reviews from strangers. Reputation is born only of deeds in which somebody stakes something. There are three roads. The first: the word of a counterparty — you had a dealing with someone, and that person sets down in writing that you kept it. And their word is not free: each member may attest only a few times a day, may vouch for no more weight than they themselves carry, and repeating always with the same crony is worth less each time. Your word is worth what you are worth, and it wears out if you waste it.

The second road: the vouch. A member with a name may put their name on the line so you can enter. But vouching is no favour: it is a bond. If the one vouched for commits fraud, the blow climbs the chain and bites the one who vouched too — with a cap, so a traitor cannot ruin an honest sponsor in one strike, and with a ripening period: a freshly given vouch must survive a whole dawn before it can drag anyone down. So whoever opens the door thinks twice, and the chains of trust are real.

The third: work for the network itself — keeping your node awake, taking your turn, validating. The chain itself measures it and writes it down, with no one having to attest. With those deeds, every day at dawn, all the nodes recompute everyone's name at once — with the same arithmetic, down to the last digit. There is no scoring committee and no server that corrects: the ledger belongs to everyone, or it belongs to no one.

Power is lived, not inherited

And not even what you earn stays still. Reputation fades if you stop playing: its half-life is twenty-four months — in one full turn, your name falls by half. The number is not round by chance. Twenty-four is two and four: the two faces of the Harlequin's mask, and the four suits in which the name is won. Either you keep playing all four hands, or you fade. It is no punishment: it is a rhythm. No one sits on their throne forever — not even the founders, who if they fall silent drop below the average citizen in little more than one turn.

And there is something else, stronger still: the first-comer's advantage dilutes on its own as the community grows. The more people enter and earn their name, the less the earlier ones weigh —

the weight is shared out, not piled into a few hands. No authority is perpetual; it is written into the constitution, and the network itself enforces it.

That is why the founders start with no edge that lasts. Zero coin, and of reputation only a minimal, declared seed — just enough for the network to take its first step, written in plain sight into block zero — which dissolves on its own with time. They are four masks that sow that first trust, one for each suit; and a fifth —the Harlequin who unites them— that only keeps the key and sows no reputation at all. They step aside as people come in. The four earn their place by validating, like anyone. The masks leave the stage when the people enter.

How it decides without a king

Who certifies the chain's history, if nobody is in charge? A committee — but a committee that is neither elected nor bought: it is drawn by lot. Every hour, chance deals the seats among those who carry a name, with more tickets the greater the name; and every day, with the recount, the deck changes. Nobody knows in advance who will be drawn, nobody digs in, and an army of nameless masks holds zero tickets: a thousand disguises are not a thousand voices.

And the draw itself is armoured against cheats. The lot is cast with a common fire: each node commits its spark in secret — sealed before knowing anything — and reveals it afterwards, when it can no longer be changed. From the blend of all the sparks comes the chance that deals the seats. Nobody can rig what was sealed blind.

There remains the last defence, the gravest of all: if in spite of everything a single entity ever concentrated too much weight, the network does not obey it — it freezes. It would rather halt, reversibly, than write history under a master. It thaws on its own when the weight spreads out again. Between obeying a captor and waiting, Harlequin waits: it is the machine translation of the first principle — stillness before servitude.

Justice, drawn by lot

When two masks collide, there is no career judge and no standing court — a fixed judge is a purchasable judge. A jury is drawn by lot from those who carry a name in the suit of judgement, and the draw comes with three bolts: the parties are out; whoever has ties to the parties is out or weighs less — the draw reads the graph of vouches, and even the crony's crony enters with their weight cut down —; and the jurors must stand far from one another, so that no clan judges its own cause. The verdict demands a broad majority, and its sentence is the only one that exists here: the name. There is no cell and no fine at gunpoint — reputation is lost, which is to lose one's place. And the verdict judges the mask; it never seeks the face behind it.

The two coins

Harlequin has two coins, and neither is printed at will. Both have a hard cap that is never exceeded — no endless inflation, no central bank, no one who gets to make money out of nothing.

The Sovereign (SOV) is the store of value: scarce, slow, to hold for the long term. Its name comes from the gold sovereign, the coin of the free — the reserve is your sovereignty. Its cap is fifty-four million, the figure of the whole deck: fifty-two cards and the two jokers, the two harlequins. The hard coin carries the mark of the house in its number.

The Purse (HLQ) is the coin of work: quick, liquid, for everyday use — to pay, to earn, to move value. Its cap is five hundred and forty million, the same deck multiplied by ten: everyday money needs more units than a reserve, but it is the same house, at another scale.

Both enter circulation little by little, along a public curve that issues less and less as it nears its cap, and are shared out among those who give real service to the network — not among those who hold the most, not among those who speculate. The curve is deliberately flat: whoever arrives late earns much like whoever came first, so that no one captures the network for having been there earlier. And there is a counterweight: part of every fee is burned, so that what comes in on one side goes out on another. The coin only rises along the curve toward a finite cap, and only falls by fire.

The nodes that hold the network up are paid for the service the chain itself measures — the turn served, the vote cast —, never for being rich: money buys no turns. And being paid gives no voice: payment is for maintaining, and only the name commands. There is a per-node ceiling — nobody counts more than twice the common measure — so the network does not become the game of the strongest. Today that measured service is validating; paying pure hosting too, for those who serve without a committee seat, is on the road, and will be said with the same honesty when it is there.

How it is governed: written rules, short-leashed power

Harlequin has a constitution — its manifesto —: twelve principles that define what may and may not be done. Two ideas hold it up. First: no office holds more power than what is written down; you cannot stretch "the common good" to grab more. Second: the commons is a closed list — only what the constitution says is shared is shared; the rest is yours. Your life, your property, and your dealings are yours alone. When in doubt, the individual wins.

Justice exists, but not as you know it. It has no prison and no sword, and it imposes no punishment: it tells the truth. When someone aggresses — steals, deceives, harms one who did not consent — a jury drawn by lot (whom no one can buy, because no one knows in advance who it will be) investigates and declares in public what the mask did. And there it stops. It does not strike, it does not lock away, and above all it does not touch their coins — not even the worst offender's. For the day this society could take what is someone's "in the name of justice," it would have become the very thing it was born against. And it acts always on the mask and the deed, never piercing anonymity.

Punishment, if it comes, is not dealt by the jury: it is dealt by people. Once the truth is known, each person decides whether to keep dealing with the one who aggressed or to withdraw their trust. To lose the name and the standing you earned — that is expulsion; never the property. And it does not fall on you by decree: it is something you accepted when you put on the mask, written and in plain view, the way one signs before entering. There is always a way back: repair the harm and earn your name again, slowly, with the one thing that cannot be faked — time.

How you join

You perform the rite of entry and receive your mask and your wallet — a single key, in your own keeping. You enter the society's panel: you see the live network, your reputation, the market and, once it is ready, the encrypted chat. And you take part: you contribute, you give service,

you earn your name. Holding the network up by running a node is simple — it fits even in a phone — and goes through the same rite: your node binds to your mask by a signature, without copying any secret.

This is not a utopia: it has happened before

It sounds like a dream, but it is not. For centuries, people with no law but their word sustained trade, credit and justice without any State to enforce it. The merchants of the medieval Mediterranean trusted one another across a thousand miles, with no contract to bring before any judge, because whoever cheated one was marked before all and never traded again. Craft guilds governed themselves, with ranks earned through proven work, and answered for their own. Medieval Iceland had no king for three hundred years. The punishment was neither prison nor the sword: it was to stop existing for your own people, to lose the name that cost so much to earn — and that threat was enough, because it struck at the only thing that truly mattered.

All those worlds shared a strength and a crack. The strength: it was earned trust, not money or arms, that carried weight. The crack: someone — a private judge, a guild master — had to keep the ledger of who could be trusted, and that person could be corrupted or could vanish. Iceland fell exactly there: once power could be bought and inherited, a few accumulated it and war came.

Harlequin takes the strength and closes the crack. The ledger of trust is not kept by a judge who can be bought: it is kept by the chain, which does not lie and which anyone can read. And power cannot pile up unchecked, because it fades if it is not played and it spreads as the community grows. We did not invent trust without a State — we inherited it from a thousand years of free people, and we finish it with the tools they never had.

Nothing is claimed without proof

Everything said so far is built and attacked before it is told. Armies of fake masks were thrown at the reputation engine, rings of cronies praising one another, name-launderers, patient traitors — seventeen ways to break it, and all seventeen failed, and anyone can re-run them on their own machine, because the code and the tests are public. Every technical claim of the project is tied, in a public validation ledger, to the run that supports it: what was claimed, how it was attacked, what came out, how to repeat it. Where something is not there yet — and things remain, named plainly in the paper — the gap is declared rather than papered over. A society born of not trusting power cannot ask to be trusted on its word.

Why it is different

It is not just another cryptocurrency. It is an attempt to build a small and just society: truly anonymous, where merit weighs more than money, with written rules that keep power on a short leash, and an economy that rewards sustaining the community rather than speculating on it. And it is tested against real adversaries before it is given value, because a promise of freedom that breaks at the first push frees no one.

It is free and open source. You can read the manifesto, read the paper, run a node, or simply look. Little by little, with no master.

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